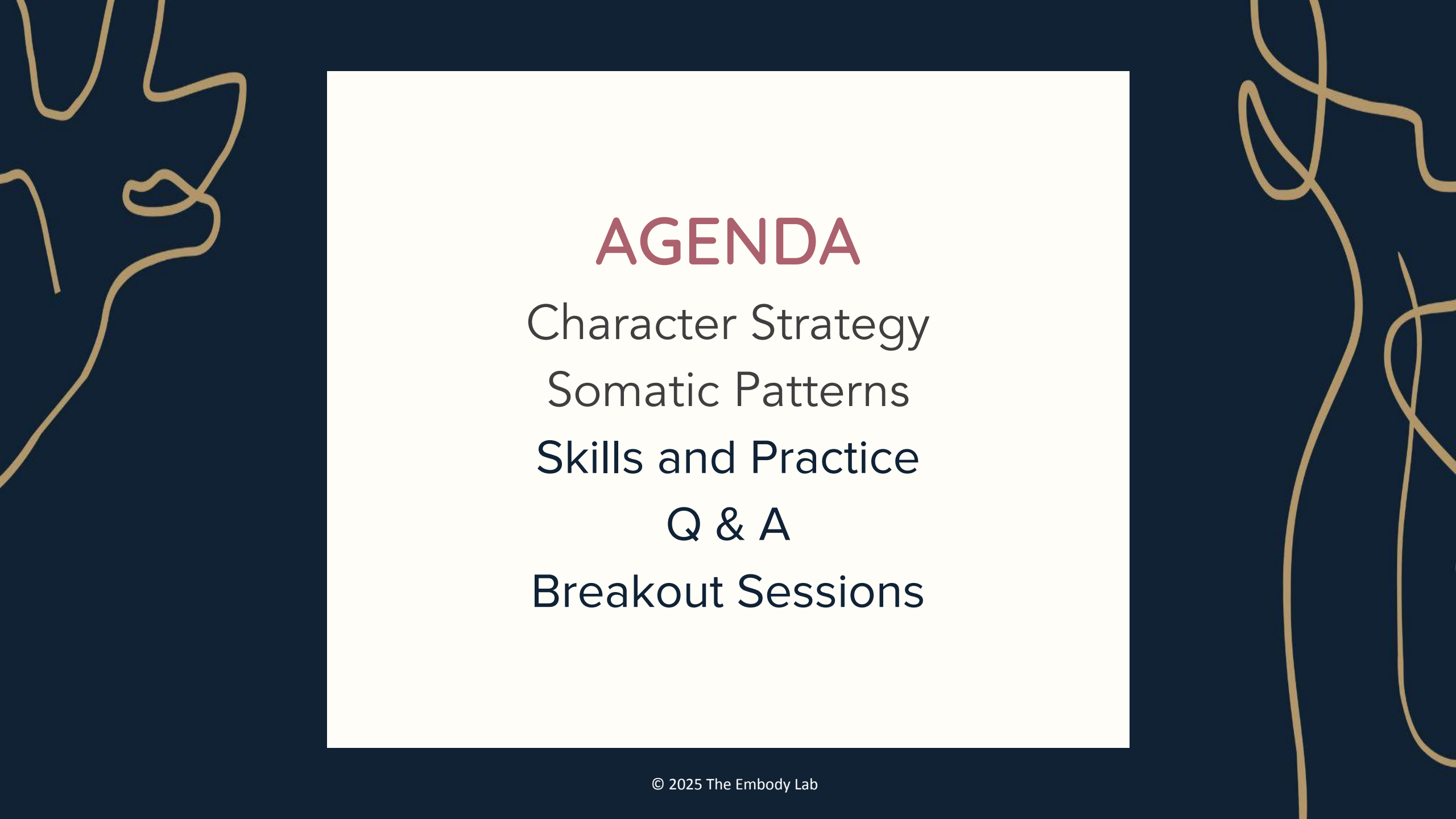


Character Strategies of the Independent Stage (1.5–3 years)

with Manuela Mischke-Reeds, MFT





AGENDA

Character Strategy

Somatic Patterns

Skills and Practice

Q & A

Breakout Sessions

Arriving Practice

- Sensing - (Body Boundaries)
- Growing – (Spine of Independence)
- Velocity- (Impulse and action)
- Pushing – (Boundaries with Play)



Development and Somatic Organization

Core Developmental Task

- Expand physical mobility
- Innate desire for exploration, independence and self-directed action
- Child experiments with:
 - "I can/want to do this."



Somatic Organization

- Impulses towards action and uprightness
- Movement of the body that includes, climbing, pulling, pushing, uprightness in the body. New relationship to gravity, sense of velocity in space. “I can propel myself.”
- Child often does not like to be contained or constraint in their exploration and action seeking.
- Movement “away” from parent/caregiver is dominate, seeking mastery of body movement.

Key Themes

- Autonomy – “I want to try it myself.”
- Willpower and impulses – “I want to act and explore”
- Boundary formation – “I am separate from you.”
- The right to have needs and preferences- ” I like, I want...”



Relational dynamic

- Tension arises when caregiver wants to restrict or control.
- The need for autonomy is met with control shame and dominance or inconsistent support
- Early relational experiences lead to implicit beliefs around self efficacy, permission to act and relational safety
- If the need for autonomy is not supported the relational dynamic becomes a push-pull between my needs and needing to comply.
- The inner need for autonomy is acted out or repressed and held in the body in tension pattern

Somatic Markers in Therapy

- Posture that reflect assertion, containment or collapse
- Forces of burden and heaviness
- Inhibiting impulses
- Chronic muscle patterns in legs, pelvis, diaphragm and jaw reflecting the tension between impulse and inhibition



Keleman,
1985

Exc. Action & Inhibition





Character

Character

- Character is a long-term shaping of personality that emerges from early experiences.
- It's a set of adaptive strategies, somatic patterns that the child develops in response to early needs not being met.
- These strategies become adult character traits that bias creating meaning, how they respond to stress, form relationships and regulate emotions.
- The body is shaped in response to these inner "realities", muscular patterns, posture, breath and movement patterns reflect and reinforce the inner beliefs.

"Character is not merely a psychological belief, it is an embodied experience that shapes the person; lived reality, creating patterns that feel fixed and unchanged from the inside."

Exc. Interdependence to Independence

- Interdependence- Strategy of self-reliance (1.5 yr)
- Authenticity –Strategy of Expansion (2-2.5 yrs)
- Freedom – Strategy if Enduring (2.5-3yrs)

Independence at 1.5 years

- Threshold from interdependence to independence
- Progression from crawling, standing, walking to “walking away”
- Instead of being helped, the child feels let down = internalized experience will be I won't be supported
- Self-reliance surfaces: “You are not there for me so, I will do this myself”, feeling disappointed and limited in the mechanics of the body.
- Beliefs: Others don't help. My needs don't matter. Expect disappointment.
- Self-reliant is cultural reinforced and celebrated. “Best not to ask for help, Do it yourself.”

2- 2.5 years

- Complex task such as opening doors, and walking, running, climbing are being mastered
- The environment becomes more interesting, sees themselves in the context of their relationships. Others become a source for connection and intimacy and source of frustration.
- Conflicts arise between inner needs, desires and will and being contained, overridden or dominated.
- The “will” is being often misinterpreted by Parents as “bad behavior” and against the parents” not seen as the first trials of independence within interdependence.
- Childs will is met with ridicule, being shamed or dominated or anger.
- Child needs to navigate this threat of power.

3 years

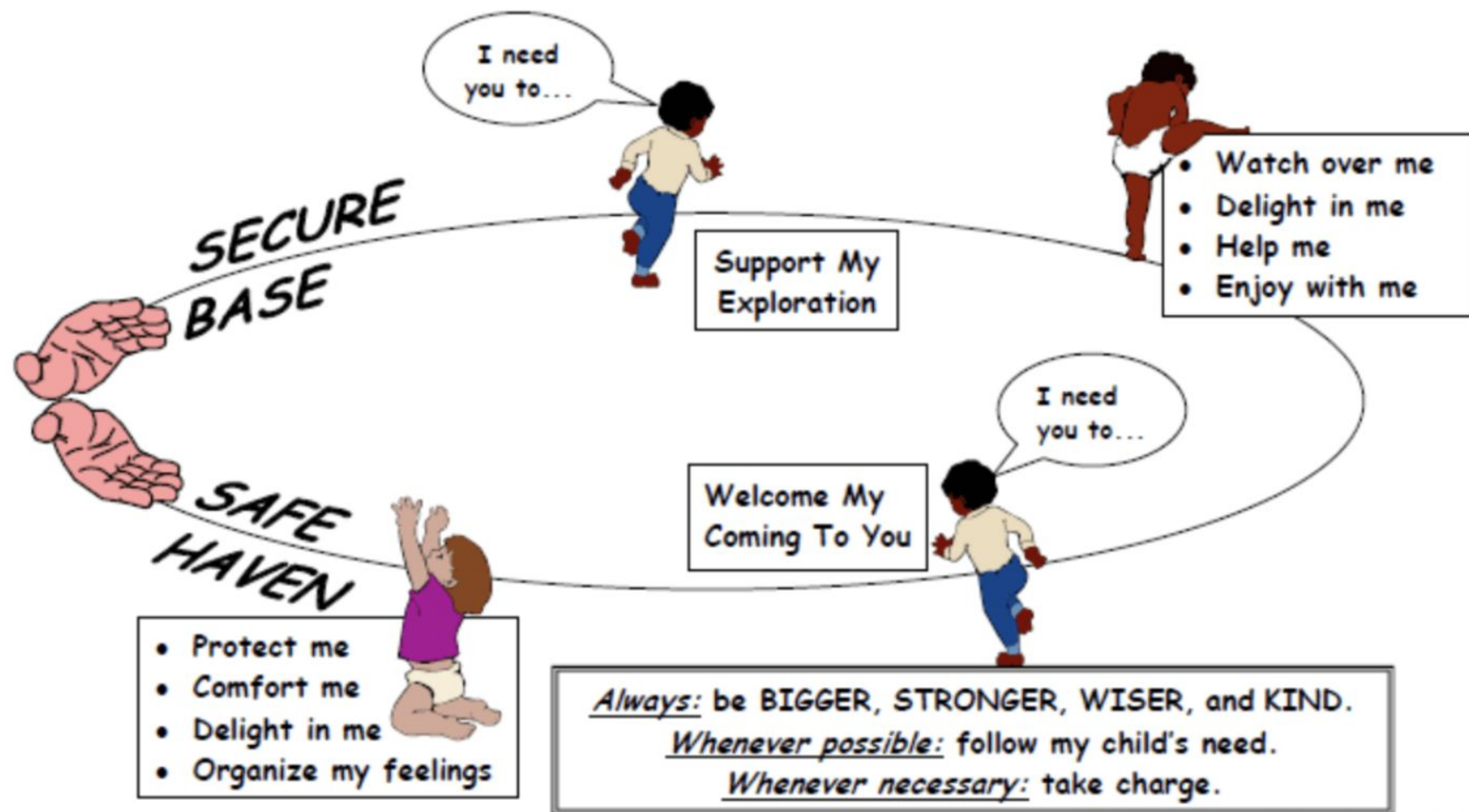
- High activity and exploration- initiating and choice making
- Start of parallel play, learning to take turns, early socializing behavior, early stage of empathy
- Erickson's stage of Initiative vs. guilt: a supported child feels confident to try new things, unsupported excessive guilt and fear of making mistakes, inhibition
- Parents can support with patience, non-criticism and empowering simple decisions, not overriding impulses to try
- Child needs positive mirroring and encouragement

Safe Haven & Secure Base

- Toddler moves towards caregiver for safety and reassurance under stress
- Seeks “Safe Haven” to receive reassurance and encouragement to explore
- Seeks “Secure Base” to explore the world. Away from the caregiver.

CIRCLE OF SECURITY

PARENT ATTENDING TO THE CHILD'S NEEDS



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circleofsecurity.org

3 years: Safe Haven & Secure Base

Safe haven behaviors:

- Seeking caregiver after a fall, conflict, or fear
- Checking caregiver's emotional availability
- Calming faster with caregiver presence or voice
- Using words *and* proximity ("Hold me," climbing into lap)

A well-functioning safe haven at this age supports:

- Emotional regulation
- Initiative and confidence
- Reduced anxiety and shame

Character- Enduring/Assertive

- Core wound: "My will is too much."
"I must push through alone."
- Protective Strategy:
 - Over-effort, self reliance, stubborn persistence
 - Difficulty receiving support, ambivalence about dependence



Character- Enduring Somatic Presentation

- Strong muscles, over bounded and density in the body
- Forward driven energy, tension in the jaw, legs etc.
- Holding the breath to brace or power through

Character- Enduring Relational Style

- Assertive or oppositional
- Fiercely independent
- May resist guidance and suggestions
- Resist vulnerability

Exc. Character- Enduring/Assertive

How do you organize internally?

How do you organize somatically?

What is the psychological conflict?

Character- Enduring Compliant/Adaptive

- Core Wound: “My autonomy is not welcome.” “ To be safe, I must comply.”
- Protective Strategy:
 - Inhibition of personal will
 - Over-adaptational to caregivers
 - Avoiding conflict or self-assertion
 - Inner conflict of complying and internal resistance

Character- Compliant Somatic Presentation

- Density in the body, withholding of impulses
- Restriction in pelvis, legs, inhibited movement
- Collapsing patterns in chest
- Bracing in pelvis area

Character- Relational style

- Accommodating of other peoples needs, conflict avoidant
- Difficulty stating preferences
- Push pull relational dynamics
- Inner anger/rage that is held and can't be expressed

Exc. Character Compliant/Adaptive

- How do you organize internally?
- How do you organize somatically?
- What is the psychological conflict?



QUESTIONS



BREAKOUT SESSIONS

Discussion Prompts

1. In what ways does the therapeutic relationship function as a *safe haven* for adult clients? Discuss how you can provide this for your clients.
2. How do your tone, pacing, boundaries, and emotional availability support (or disrupt) the client's ability to regulate and explore difficult Character material?
3. Reflect on your own Character development? What do you recognize as patterns in your body and what beliefs are associated with it. What have you found helpful in working with these?